

Do you suffer from software rage? Bug-free software is just an update away

Every PC user has suffered through a software crash—it's universal and knows no caste, colour or creed. Though the crash may be due to hardware failure or electrical surges, most often than not, the software itself is to be blamed.

Developers walk the tightrope when it comes to software release deadlines. Cutthroat competition and pressing demands from customers drive software makers to tighten already unrealistic project schedules. Most developers put their development cycles on their Web sites and sometimes even take feedback from consumers during development. This compels them to shorten the test phase, and often the software is packed off with a few major and minor bugs.

Bugs can be broadly classified as security holes and software errors—the former is deadlier and often paves the way for the latter. Remember all those times Word crashed for no apparent reason? Or when Windows gave you the blue screen of death? These are software errors, which generally mean loss of data or just plain irritation. Security breaches are more dangerous and the software must be patched immediately, or else the system becomes vulnerable to hostile bodies.

A stitch in time

Competition and customer complaints get software companies to release updates and fix bugs as and when necessary. There are various services on the Net that send out regular newsletters letting you know of bugs that have been discovered, along with the fixes and updates that have been released. Many software include an automatic update feature that regularly checks the developer's Web site, and downloads and installs the new version. This trend began with anti-virus software, trickled down to Internet-related software such as browsers and chat clients, and has now spread to office applications and operating systems. Many of these can be configured to automatically download and



PHOTOGRAPH: Jiten Gandhi IMAGING: Solomon Lewis

install updates, but it is advisable to have them ask for confirmation before installing the update.

Updates are not only patches for bugs. New releases of the software with added features, performance enhancements, better user-interfaces and higher customisability are also distributed through updates, usually free for existing registered users. Microsoft distributed two Service Releases (SR) for Office 97 that had patches for the bugs in the Office suite, especially Outlook, and enhanced the HTML support for Word. The support became dramatically better and Word crashed less often when working with HTML files.

Updating Windows

The best place to get updates for Windows is right from the horse's mouth—Microsoft itself! If you are using Windows 98 or a later version and are connected to the Internet, click 'Windows Update'



Scan Windows 2000 PCs with MBSA

from the Startup menu or go to <http://windowsupdate.microsoft.com>. When you click on 'Product Updates', an applet will detect your operating system and give you a list of updates that it does not find on your computer. These are categorised as 'Critical Updates', 'Picks of the Month', 'Recommended Updates', 'Additional Windows Features' and 'Device Drivers'. Read through the descriptions of each update, select the ones you want and click 'Download'. The updates will be downloaded and installed on your PC.

If you are using Windows 2000 or XP, the Microsoft Baseline Security Analyser (MBSA) is a good tool to analyse your operating system and locate relevant patches for it. You can scan one or more computers with this tool and it provides you with options to check for weaknesses in Windows, passwords, Internet Information Services (IIS), SQL and hotfixes. The security report can be sorted by name or severity of the vulnerability. For each notification you can look up what exactly was scanned and how you can correct it.

Another handy tool for Windows NT and 2000 is QChain from Microsoft. It is a command-line tool that can install multiple hotfixes in one go, without requiring you to reboot after every patch. This is most useful with a fresh installation, or if you haven't updated your operating system for a long time.

Updating Office and Internet Explorer

Just like Windows, Microsoft has a detection tool for Office 2000 and XP that locates updates for your suite at <http://office.microsoft.com>. Click 'Product Updates' and choose the automatic detection engine or just jump to the 'Download Center' and select the patches you want from the list.

Keep an eye out for Service Packs (or Service Releases), since this is the best way to update Office. At the Download Center, you can filter the list for specific applications rather than the entire suite. This gives you more control over what →